CHAPTER 4

One and Several: Gharjistan, Chisht, and Imperial Firuzkuh

The architectural corpus analyzed here spans approximately the late 1160s–1170s, encompassing the Firuzkuh Shansabanis' *sard-sir* "capital" and other sites radiating westward toward Herat, and northwest to Gharjistan. The buildings and complexes consist of the following examples, discussed in the proposed chronological order, which is, admittedly, at some variance with previous scholarship: The *madrasa* known as Shah-i Mashhad near Jawand in Gharjistan (Figure 4.1), which was founded in AH 561/1164–1165 CE and likely completed a decade later, probably also included a tomb (Figure 4.5).[1] Chisht's two domed structures, one with a *mihrab* (Figures 4.12 and 4.17), evidently belonged to a larger complex that was possibly a *madrasa*, located east of Herat and dated by inscription to AH 562/1167 CE (construction and renovation probably extending before and after this date). Finally, the famous *minar* of Jam-Firuzkuh (Figure 4.18), also discussed in Chapter 3, has an inscription that was re-read as dating to AH 569/1174 CE, superseding the previous reading of AH 590/1193–1194 CE (cf. below). All of these buildings and sites are important surviving examples of monumental architectural initiatives within the purview of the Firuzkuh Shansabanis.

Although the Bamiyan Shansabanis – discussed in Chapter 3 – doubtless undertook architectural projects in their territories, the absence of firmly datable evidence makes further examination of their patronage quite difficult, with the possible exception of forays into the Balkh oasis.[2] It should also be noted that, by this period, the Firuzkuh and Ghazna Shansabanis' building activities included, respectively, monumental architecture and extensive interventions in pre-existing complexes, the latter phenomenon also calling for a concentrated analysis in its own right in Chapter 5. As will be subsequently discussed in detail, the documentable architectural footprints specifically of the Ghazna Shansabanis in Afghanistan – and by extension those of the architectural culture of the eastern Persianate world – were particularly impactful throughout their campaigns farther east, first to the Indus's alluvia and ultimately to India (see also Volume II).

A significant difference between the preceding chapter's earlier architectural group and the one analyzed here is the extensive architectural epigraphy on the latter, at times warranting discussion at some length (cf.